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Returned owlets spread wings over birthplace

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NEW SALEM — When humans collide with wildlife, the results are sometimes disastrous.

Other times though, the outcome can be, well, breathtaking.

Such was the case one evening last week, when, on a parched soybean field, Union County farmer Earl Simpson flung open several cardboard boxes, releasing five baby barn owls into the wild.

At first, the owlets, startled by the rush of twilight, slowly eased out of the makeshift cages. But then, like the legs of a child trying a first solo walk, the owlets' wings took control — quickly lifting the brown and white birds skyward.

As their wings flapped rhythmically, a solemn silence fell over the gathering of 15 who had come to witness the moment. The liberation was especially poignant for Simpson, for it was he who rescued the owlets from a soybean silo eight weeks earlier.

"It's nice to see them actually flying," Simpson said, shielding his eyes to catch a glimpse of the owls as they glided across a blazing orange and red sunset. "I was afraid they might not be able to fly."

Simpson's worries were understandable. Last time he encountered the

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— **Mathias Engelmann**, Raptor Center spokesman

youngsters, they were 5-week-old frightened downy babes roosting in his grain bin — a bin that had to be emptied.

But when Simpson and some friends tried to rouse the birds into a cage, the two eldest took to the air with miserable results — one careened head-first into a parked truck, and the other made a crash landing. The remaining three were far too callow to even attempt an aeronautical maneuver.

All were gathered and taken to the Carolina Raptor Center in Mecklenburg County, where they spent a few days in intensive care before being moved to flight cages to build muscles and prac-

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DAVIE HINSHAW/Staff

Welcome back: Earl Simpson releases a barn owl at his farm in Union County. He rescued the owlets from a soybean silo 8 weeks ago and took them to the Raptor Center.

Young owls spread maturing wings over birthplace after rescue from silo

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tice catching mice.

"When we got these barn owls, they were too young to fly and too young to have ever caught their own food," said Mathias Engelmann, raptor center spokesman. "My guess is that if they had been taken from the silo and left on their own, they may not have made it. They needed time in the cages to become strong."

The barn owl is a protected species whose numbers have dropped drastically during the past few years. Silos and barns are popular roosting and nesting spots, but since many of the older structures have been taken down, the barn owl is considered a species of special concern.

The flying practice at the Raptor Center must have helped, for the owlets' effortless soaring made them seem like veteran pilots. They took off for the far corners of Simpson's 1,000-acre farm, soaring high above the hardwood trees.

Ideally, Engelmann said, barn owls should be released near their first home. But, he said, there is no guarantee the owlets will stay in the area very long.

Nonetheless, Simpson holds out hope.

"I think they'll like it here," he said, of the special spot he'd chosen to release the birds. "There's lots of room, an old barn for them to sleep in, and plenty of field mice."

Helping the birds

Here's what to do if you find an orphaned or abandoned baby raptor. Raptors are birds of prey, such as eagles, owls, hawks, falcons and vultures:

1. Call the Carolina Raptor Center immediately at (704) 875-6521. It will assist with arrangements to transport the bird to the center. It is illegal to possess a raptor without state and federal permits.

2. Carefully catch the bird — watch out for its talons and beak. Even a weak bird will try to defend itself. Use a pair of heavy gloves.

3. Carefully cover the bird with a towel or blanket to pick it up, taking care to fold its wings back against its body.

4. Place the bird in a sturdy cardboard box just a little larger than the bird. Put a blanket or towel in the bottom and cut ventilation holes near the base of the box. Place the box in a warm, quiet, dark place.

5. Do not try to water or feed the bird. Feeding it the wrong thing may kill it, and it may not be strong enough to digest solid food.